

Narrative Transportation

What is it?

People mentally enter the world of a story and temporarily disconnect from their real surroundings.

History

Studied in communication psychology since around **2000**, where researchers found that vivid storytelling immerses people emotionally, making them more open to influence without noticing it.

The Psychology Behind It

- Stories activate emotional and sensory brain areas
- Immersion reduces resistance and skepticism
- People think, feel, and react as if they are in the story world
- Narrative framing can shape beliefs, decisions, and actions

Why It Matters

- Creates strong emotional engagement
- Improves brand loyalty
- Can cause users to miss facts hidden behind the story
- Risk of persuasion leading to biased choices
- Over-promising can break trust

How to Apply It

- Combine storytelling with real information (data, evidence, product facts)
- Use authentic stories from real users and real journeys
- Use visuals — videos, images, timelines, scenarios — to deepen immersion
- Keep stories relevant, relatable, and purpose-driven

Theory in Action

- Airbnb leverages host stories and guest experiences to make people imagine their own trips, building emotional desire before logical intent

Final Thought

Stories influence action more than raw information.

Use narrative power carefully — guide emotion without overshadowing clarity.